

Since your team is working **remotely from their own homes**, they cannot use your local network IP (192.168.0.105) directly because it is blocked behind your home router's firewall.

To bridge this gap, you need to use an approach called **environment variables**. Instead of hardcoding credentials, each developer's computer will use a separate hidden configuration file (.env). This allows **you** to connect locally to 127.0.0.1 while **your teammates** point to your public URL.

Here is how to update your setup step-by-step:

Step 1: Install dotenv

Open your project terminal and run this command to install the package that manages hidden configurations:

```
npm install dotenv
```

Step 2: Create a .env File

In the **root folder** of your project (the same folder where your server.js lives), create a new file named exactly **.env**.

For YOUR computer, fill it out like this:

```
DB_HOST=127.0.0.1
DB_USER=root
DB_PASSWORD=
DB_NAME=careerConnect_db
```

For YOUR TEAMMATES' computers, they will use your new user details:

```
DB_HOST=YOUR_PUBLIC_IP_OR_TUNNEL_URL
DB_USER=project_tam
DB_PASSWORD=THE_PASSWORD_YOU_CREATED
DB_NAME=careerConnect_db
```

Step 3: Update your server.js Code

Replace the database connection segment in your code with this dynamic version that securely loads configuration variables:

```
// Load environment variables at the very top of your file
require('dotenv').config();

const bcrypt = require('bcrypt');
const express = require("express");
const mysql = require("mysql2");
const path = require('path');

const app = express();

const hostname = '0.0.0.0'; // Changed from '127.0.0.1' so your
Node server accepts external team requests
const port = 3000;

// Parse form data
app.use(express.urlencoded({extended:true}));

// static files
app.use(express.static(path.join(__dirname, '..', 'css')));

// Connect to DB (UPDATED TO USE ENVIRONMENT VARIABLES)
const db = mysql.createConnection({
  host: process.env.DB_HOST,
  user: process.env.DB_USER,
  password: process.env.DB_PASSWORD,
  database: process.env.DB_NAME
});

db.connect((err) => {
  if(err) {
    console.error("Database connection failed:", err);
  }
  else {
    console.log(`Connected to database:
${process.env.DB_NAME}`);
  }
});
```

Step 4: Expose your Local Database to the Internet

Because your team is remote, they still cannot see your computer. You have two options to fix this:

- **Option A: Ngrok (Fastest & Easiest)**
 1. Download and open **ngrok**.
 2. Expose your database port by running: `ngrok tcp 3306`
 3. Ngrok will give you an address like `tcp://4.tcp.ngrok.io:12345`.
 4. Your remote teammates will copy `4.tcp.ngrok.io` as their `DB_HOST` and `12345` as their port in their `.env` files.
- **Option B: Router Port Forwarding (Permanent but Manual)**
 1. Log into your home router administration page (usually `http://192.168.0.1`).
 2. Find the **Port Forwarding / Virtual Server** settings.
 3. Create a new rule forwarding port **3306** directly to your local IPv4 address: `192.168.0.105`.
 4. Search "What is my IP" on Google to find your public routing address. Your teammates will use that public IP address as their `DB_HOST`.

Would you like me to walk you through setting up **ngrok** to tunnel your port, or do you want instructions for configuring **Port Forwarding** on your router?